



United States
Attorney's Office
District of Maryland



United States Obtains More Than \$1.4 Million Judgment Against Family Medical Practitioner for Fraudulent Billing

Monday, August 11, 2025

For Immediate Release

U.S. Attorney's Office, District of Maryland

Baltimore, Maryland –The U.S. Attorney's Office for the District of Maryland (USAO-MD) announced that it obtained a judgment of \$1,407,493.23 against Dr. Richard Akoto, M.D., a family medical doctor, and his practice, Richard O. Akoto, M.D. PC, located in Takoma Park, Maryland. The U.S. District Court for the District of Maryland found that Akoto submitted, or caused the submission of, false claims to the Medicare program in connection with his use of auricular stimulation (P-Stim) devices.

U.S. Attorney Kelly O. Hayes announced the judgment with Special Agent in Charge Maureen Dixon, Department of Health and Human Services Office of Inspector General (HHS-OIG).

In his practice, Dr. Akoto used a P-stim device to treat patients for pain. A P-Stim device provides electrical acupuncture to treat pain symptoms and is applied externally to the patient, generally behind the patient's ear using an adhesive to hold the device in place. Acupuncture, electrical or otherwise, is not reimbursable by Medicare. The United States filed a complaint against Dr. Akoto alleging he falsely billed Medicare using a code for an implantable neurostimulator device, which is surgically implanted into a patient and typically performed by a surgeon in an operating room. Dr. Akoto fraudulently billed Medicare for this complex neurosurgical procedure numerous times from approximately January 17, 2019 to May 1, 2019.

"Dr. Akoto knowingly submitted false claims by billing non-invasive P-Stim devices as surgical implants—an unconscionable and blatant misrepresentation to exploit the Medicare system," Hayes said. "This type of fraud not only wastes taxpayer dollars, it also undermines trust in our healthcare system. The U.S. Attorney's office is committed to continuing to work with our partners to identify and eliminate this kind of waste and abuse of our federal health care programs."

"Accurately billing for services provided to Medicare enrollees is required of all health care providers participating in the program," Dixon said. "HHS-OIG and the U.S. Attorney's Office will continue to

evaluate and pursue inaccurate billings related to P-Stim and similar devices."

U.S. Attorney Hayes commended HHS-OIG for its work in the investigation. Ms. Hayes also thanked Thomas F. Corcoran, Chief, USAO-MD Civil Division, and Investigator Ann Thiel, for their investigation and litigation of this case.

For more information about the Maryland U.S. Attorney's Office, its priorities, and resources available to report fraud, visit justice.gov/usao-md and justice.gov/usao-md/community-outreach.

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